



Delaware County Budget Hearings September 6th 2023 Segment #1

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r7ywdv2G6RI
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Municipal Meeting Summary Report

Meeting: 2024 Budget Hearings / County Council

Date: September 6, 2023

Presiding Officer: Not explicitly stated (Addressed as Madam President / Board President)

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1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

- Session Type & Topic:** [00:06:19](#) Kickoff of the 2024 budget hearings and statutory public hearing on the proposed county budget.

- **Summary of Discussion:** Opening remarks regarding the budget process. No public sign-ups were registered in advance, but the floor was opened for public testimony on the upcoming budget cycle.
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2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** 00:06:19 The meeting was called to order by the presiding officer on September 6, 2023, initiating the 2024 budget hearings.
 - **Attendance:**
 - *Members Present:* Bill, Fiber, Jim, Bam, Ryan, and President (full roster participated via roll call).
 - *Members Absent:* None noted.
 - *Presiding Officer:* Board President (named in transcript as "Madam President" / presiding chair).
 - *Board Attorney:* Bill (Legal Counsel).
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** 00:06:27 The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance led by Gavin.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** Not addressed during this session.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

(Note: Per strict guidelines, numerical vote tallies are omitted as all votes during these budget hearings were conducted by voice consensus or discussion without formal roll call counts.)

- **00:09:42 Auditor's Office / Financial Outlook Presentation**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tanya (Auditor's Office) and board leadership.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presentation of official numbers from the Department of Local Government Finance (DLGF). Estimated general revenue is up \$700,000, and fall tax collections are up \$451,000. However, second-half expenditures are up \$2 million, the June 30 cash balance is down \$1.1 million, and the December 31 balance is projected down \$1.3 million. Continuing appropriations for 2023 reached \$641,466 out of \$817,519 appropriated. Departments requested an additional \$6.4 million for County General in 2024. The county requires a \$6 million operating balance to bridge June and December tax settlements. To avoid borrowing, the council faces a major deficit requiring spending cuts or freezes.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation; consensus to use 2023 budget figures as a baseline and recommend a freeze on new non-emergency appropriations. Approved by Voice Vote.

- **00:23:41 Data Processing / Information Technology (IT) Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jim (IT Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Jim presented the IT budget, noting minor line-item adjustments. Increases include \$1,500 for computer peripherals (display port adapters for new PCs) and contractual services under a 3-year commissioner contract (Year 2). Hardware maintenance covers a 10% to 12% vendor increase for servers and network switches. Discussions touched upon network security/SIM solutions and ransomware prevention.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed for baseline adjustment. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **00:43:51 Purdue Extension Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Extension Office representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Proposed budget is up roughly \$7,000, driven by a 4% salary increase for two county-paid employees and a 4% increase in the mandated Purdue land-grant university contract. Discretionary lines remain flat.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **00:48:01 Treasurer's Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brad (County Treasurer).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed line items including salary adjustments for bookkeepers and chief deputies, \$1,200 for cashier computer replacements on a multi-year rotation, and a reduction in bank fees and printing costs due to local bank investments and new print contractors. Investment income is projected to reach \$2 million to \$3 million for the year.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:05:01 Surveyor's Office & Drainage Board Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tom (County Surveyor) / Brandy Ingerman & Kylene Slackhammer (Plan Commission).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed general fund requests and specialized funds (Surveyor's Perpetuation Fund and Drainage Board budget). Discussion covered drainage board member compensation (\$1,500/year per member for monthly public meetings managing 800+ miles of regulated drains), legal and statutory obligations, and historical assessment rates unchanged since the 1980s.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:36:13 Assessor's Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Assessor's Office representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed County General and Reassessment funds. Noted flat discretionary spending, a 4% salary adjustment guideline, and the completion of a one-time property record card online posting fee (\$2,000 removed for 2024). Postage costs shifted internally from the Commissioners' budget.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:47:43 Recorder's Office Budget Review**

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Recorder's Office representative.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed the Recorder's budget and the Recorder's Perpetuation Fund (Balance: \$1,136,908 as of June 30). Staffing includes positions split between County General and perpetuation funds. Fee distributions under state statute were outlined. Revenues are down due to cooling retail housing markets and higher interest rates.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:04:15 Plan Commission Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brandy Ingerman (Office Manager) & Kylene Slackhammer (Principal Planner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Addressed the ongoing vacancy of the Executive Director position (vacant for 229 days) following the departure of Marta. Discussed the lack of progress on a city-county interlocal agreement for funding executive leadership. Highlighted permit revenue increases and state grant reimbursements (80% match on program staff salaries, bringing in over \$202,000 year-to-date). Requested converting a part-time secretary position to full-time (a 3.5-hour weekly increase) to handle surging building permits.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:19:59 Coroner's Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Coroner's Office representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented a revised budget reflecting a reduction of \$11,000 under 2023 baseline levels. Autopsy funding requests were reduced from \$300,000 to \$235,000 based on mortality trends. Wishlist items and staff training will be covered using remaining 2023 funds or external grants (Ball Brothers Foundation).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Revised budget accepted. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:27:22 Convention and Tourism Bureau Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Kevin Kirby (CEO), Dylan Carpenter (Treasurer), & Brandon Murphy (Attorney).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Requested \$916,898 funded entirely through Innkeeper's Tax revenue (outside the county property tax Max Levy). Outlined economic impact metrics (ranking 22nd out of 96 in state visitor revenue), upcoming branding and marketing campaigns, hotel additions, and strategic partnerships. Addressed council inquiries regarding sponsorship vetting processes and community event policies.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:43:49 County Fairgrounds Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Donna (Fairgrounds representative).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Maintained flat budget lines, adjusting utility accounts. Noted upcoming utility appropriation transfers to cover electricity and sewage

expenses. Projected year-end cash balance around \$284,000 and 2024 revenues around \$360,000.

- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:49:58 GIS / Office of Information & GIS Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Kyle (GIS/IT representative).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Budget remains flat except for a 4% salary increase. Software maintenance costs increased, but 80% is reimbursed via state matching grants. Operating out of the EOC with EMA and 911.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:51:58 Emergency Management Agency (EMA) Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** EMA Director.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed County General and Local Emergency Planning Committee (LEPC non-reverting) funds. Noted 50% salary reimbursement via the EMPG federal/state grant (\$64,246 match). Minor adjustments made to uniform lines, dropping unused contract printing allocations.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:57:16 Emergency Medical Services (EMS) Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** EMS Director.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed budget pressures, overtime utilization due to medical leaves and staffing shortages, and utility cost trends (noting natural gas prices are down 72%). Addressed staffing challenges regarding EMTs transitioning to paramedic school and retention strategies. Director agreed to review line items overnight to align closer to 2023 baseline figures.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Held for overnight review and redrafting. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **03:13:38 Communications / 911 Center Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Fred (911 Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Highlighted surging call volumes: 7,600 increase in calls for service and 4,500 increase in phone calls in 2023 compared to prior years. Addressed a 5-year funding agreement signed with the city of Muncie (\$1 million for 2023, increasing \$25,000 annually). Muncie calls represent 47.14% of total volume. Discussed the 911 Fund (Fund 1222) balance of \$1.829 million, noting upcoming automated dispatch system expenditures (\$200,000 allocated) and future phone system replacement reserves. Stressed that salary and retention adjustments are critical to prevent costly turnover and retraining (\$15,000+ per dispatcher).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:07:43 Rick Yentzer** (Newsman and Author): Addressed the board during the initial public hearing. Expressed concern over the proposed \$63 million spending level and a \$1

million property tax increase. Criticized the lack of accessible public notice, timing of budget hearings during working hours, school corporation bonding practices, and past capital project debts. Urged the council to implement property tax relief for homeowners and businesses.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** Continuation of departmental budget hearings scheduled for the following day.
 - **Adjournment:** 03:41:04 The meeting recessed at 1:15 PM (noted in transcript as a return to session at 1:30 PM). Official adjournment time not specified as the session entered a lunch recess.
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